



“We were
skilled, but
we saw
terrible things ...
**people buried
alive ...**”

PHAN NGOC ANH, A WOMAN IN THE NORTH
VIETNAMESE ARMY

COMBAT AND COMMUNISM

During the Vietnam War, Ho Chí Minh (the communist leader of North Vietnam) made it clear that women were to play a vital part in war efforts alongside their male counterparts. Women were therefore exposed to the full horrors of war: many joined the North Vietnamese Army and served in support capacities as medics, supply personnel, and bomb disposal teams; others joined the Viet Cong working in rice fields and intelligence services. Whatever their role, all women in North Vietnam were taught to use weapons and fight in hand-to-hand combat, and some—often those who were young, single, and childless—took combat roles. The soldiers depicted here were part of a self-defense detachment in Hanoi that repulsed a US air attack in April 1965.